Sheringham scored the first goal, everybody in the ground knew we were going to finish off the Double. During the week before the game, the boss had told me that he was thinking of resting me. Because of injuries and Keano's suspension we were going to be short of midfielders the following Wednesday. Obviously it was his decision, in the end, that I started on Saturday, too, but I can still remember pleading with him: it was the Cup Final, after all. I didn't want to miss a single moment of this.

One strange thing happened during the course of beating Newcastle 2–0 that Saturday afternoon. I went in for a challenge with Gary Speed and his elbow caught me on the mouth. I'd cut my lip. It really stung—killed me—for the rest of the game and, when we were climbing the steps in front of the Royal Box to pickup the FA Cup, it bled quite a lot. Gary Neville pulled his shirt down over his fist and went to wipe some of it away: I didn't know how bad it looked. What I did know, though, was that it was sore enough not to want anyone near it. Back at the hotel we were staying at that evening, I met Victoria. We were in our room and I took a sip from a glass of mineral water and suddenly realized that it was dribbling out through my lip. I couldn't understand it at first. The cut had gone right through. I closed my mouth and blew, and water came spurting out through the hole: it was a weird party trick to celebrate winning the cup.

Thinking back, it feels like we had a couple of weeks after that to get ready for the Champions League Final against Bayern Munich. Actually, the game at the Nou Camp was the following Wednesday. Time just seemed to move really slowly: it was a new experience for all of us and I think we were just taking in every moment of the build-up. This was something absolutely massive, after all. Having won the Premiership and the FA Cup already, it felt like we weren't under any kind of pressure. I remember everybody being really relaxed, just looking forward to it. And I'll never forget, either, what the manager said to us in the dressing room just before we went up the tunnel to play in the biggest game of our lives.

'Trust me: you don't want to have to walk past the European Cup at the end of the game tonight. Not being able to pick it up would be the most painful thing you'll ever feel in soccer. Make sure you don't end up having to just look at that trophy, not able to touch it, knowing you had the chance to win the thing but then let that chance pass you by.'

I don't know how much the boss's warning helped focus us on what we had to do. The fact that it stuck in my mind so clearly says a lot, I think. What I know for sure is that every word he said about the pain and disappointment